

Everyday Slang

abyssinia - quick way of saying "I'll be seeing you."

aces - excellent

ackamarackus - nonsense

apple - a large city

bash - an attempt

blow your wig - get excited

boondoggle - an extravagant and useless project

booshwa/booshwash - empty talk; "bullshit"

bread - money

Brodie - to take a chance and lose; a mistake

bumping gums - making conversation, but of no substance

cheaters - glasses or sunglasses

city juice - a glass of water; used to refer to city water

cockamamie - children's slang for a decal applied to the skin
(like a temporary tattoo)

copacetic - performing well

dil-ya-ble - a phone call

dime a dozen - anything very common, not valuable

dog soup - a glass of water; used to refer to those who can't
afford to drink anything else

dough - money

eighty-six - a sold out item (food service)

five spot - five dollars

gobsmacked - flabbergasted; surprised

honey cooler - a kiss

horn - telephone

iron - a car or motorcycle

kibosh - put a stop to something

lincolns - five dollar bills

low down - all the information

make tracks - to leave; putting distance between yourself and where you were

nitiwttery - stupidity

off the cob - corny

piss or get off the pot - stop wasting time and make a decision

sawbuck - \$10 bill

shake a leg - hurry up

slip me five - "shake my hand"

slugburger - hamburger patty made with ground beef mixed with slightly stale bread

squat - zero, nothing

whacky - crazy

you and me both - a way of vocalizing agreement

Aces: Excellent

Ackamarackus: Nonsense

All wet: No good

Bash: An attempt or try

Barge around: Walk slowly

Bazoo: Mouth

Beat: Broke

Behind the grind: Behind in your work or studies

Biff: Failure

Blow, split, or scam: Leave

Blow your wig: To get excited

Bong: To catch on to a joke slowly

Boondoggle: An extravagant or useless project

Booshwash or bumping gums: Empty talk, bullsh*t

Bread, dough, moolah, or bacon: Money

Brodie: To take a chance and lose or make a mistake

Bug: Difficult to understand

Cheaters: Glasses or sunglasses

Check or checker: A dollar

Cockamamie: Kids' slang for a temporary tattoo or detail

Copacetic: Performing well

Dil-ya-ble: A phone call (sounds like "dialable")

Dime a dozen: Anything very common or not very valuable

Dog it: To avoid work

Dukes, paws, grabbers, or meat hooks: Hands

Eggs in coffee: Run smoothly

Fade: To leave

Five spot or a Lincoln: Five dollars or a five dollar bill

Frog: To cheat

Gams: Legs

Gasser: A great time or something very funny

Gobsmacked: Flabbergasted or shocked

Gumming the works: To cause something to run less smoothly, to ruin a plan

Honey cooler: A kiss

Hops: Information

Horn or blower: Telephone

Hot stuff: The latest news or trend

Iron: A car or motorcycle

Joed: Tired

Juicy: Enjoyable

Kibosh: To squelch or put a stop to something

Kippy: Neat

Low down: All the information

Meat wagon: An ambulance

Middle-aisle it: Get married

Necking: Making out

Pitching woo or making whoopee: Making love

Plotz: Sit down wearily, slouch, mope around

Sawbuck: A ten dollar bill

Snipe: Cigarette

Somoa: Some more (pronounced like you're slurring your words together)

Speedo: Speedometer

Squat: Zero or nothing

That way for: Falling in love

Tin can or flivver: A car

Trip for biscuits: A task that yields nothing

Uh-huh: Falling in love

Whacky: Crazy

Yo!: Yes

Abyssinia: "I'll be seeing you" (pronounced like you're slurring your words together)^[1]

Awgwan: "I don't believe you" or "Oh, go on"

Cute as a bug's ear: Very cute

Dizzy with a dame: In love with a woman to someone's own detriment, especially if she's someone else's moll (a gangster's girlfriend)

Fan my brow!: "What a surprise!"

Here I is: "Hello"

H'roo or hurro: "Hello"

I mean and how: "That is so true"

Mitt me, kid: "Congratulate me"

No soap!: “That isn’t possible”

Piss or get off the pot: “Stop wasting time and make a decision”

Put a bee in your bonnet: To know something interesting

Says which?: “What did you just say?”

Shake a leg: “Hurry up”

Slip me five: “Shake my hand”

What’s the score?: “What are you talking about?”

What’s your story, morning glory?: “What do you mean by that?”

You and me both: “I agree” or “same here”

You shred it, wheat: “You said it”

Yowsah: “Yes, sir”

People and Places

big butter and egg man - a rich man who spends his money on women

broad/dame/doll - woman

canary - a female singer

cats/alligators - swing music fans

cave - one's house or apartment

cement mixer - a person who is terrible at dancing

clip joint - establishment where customers get scammed

crooner - a smooth singer

crumb - unsuccessful or unreliable person

dead hooper - bad dancer

gold digger - woman who marries for money

grifter - a con artist or swindler

hep cat - someone who loves jazz music

hot mama/looker/tomato/dish/sweet patootie - good-looking woman

joe - an average guy

juke joint - an informal establishment featuring music and dancing

moll - a gangster's girlfriend

motor court - a motel

nogoodnik - a bad or worthless person

screwball - an eccentric person, originally from baseball slang

stool pigeon - an informer, "snitch"

tightwad - a stingy person

wise guy - a smart aleck

Apple: A big city or town

Cave: A house or apartment

Clip joint: A nightlife establishment or casino where customers get scammed

Grifter: A con artist or swindler

High-gear road: A road that could be traveled at a steady speed

Motor court: An early word for a motel

Pip: An attractive person

Plenty rugged: Big and strong

Smooth: Well-dressed

Togged to the bricks: Dressed up in a fancy or alluring way

Butter and egg man: A man with money who likes to spend it on women

Joe: An average guy or man

Remittance man: Someone paid by his family to stay away

Broad, babe, dame, doll, twist, muffin, kitten, or wren: General terms for a woman

Dollface: A name for a woman when a man is apologizing or trying to woo her

Fem, filly, flame, flirt, or fuss: A girl or woman who is a constant companion to a boy or man

Hot mama, looker, butter and egg fly, sweet patootie, dish, or tomato: An attractive or good-looking woman

Drugs and Alcohol Slang

booze - whiskey

cadillac - an ounce of cocaine or heroin

giggle juice - whiskey

hooch - whiskey

jive - marijuana

muggles - marijuana

rotgut - bad or cheap liquor

weed - marijuana

Booze, hooch, or giggle juice: Whiskey

Cadillac: 1 ounce of cocaine or heroin

Gin mill: Any place that serves liquor, sometimes illegally

Jive, muggles, or weed: Marijuana

Plonk: Cheap or low-quality wine

Rotgut: Bad or cheap homemade liquor

Speakeasy: A bar disguised as something else or hidden behind an unmarked door

Swacked: Drunk, intoxicated

Law Enforcement

big house - prison

bust out - to escape from jail or prison

buzzer - police badge

Chicago overcoat - a coffin

Chicago typewriter/Tommy gun - Thompson machine gun

convincer/gat/heater/rod - gun

copper - police officer

dick/gumshoe/flatfoot - a detective

goons - enforcers, tough guys

on sus - suspected of committing a crime

on the lam - fleeing from law enforcement

take for a ride - to drive someone away to murder them

taking the rap/fall - taking responsibility for someone else's crime

trigger men - hired gunmen

Bleed: To extort or blackmail

Bust out: To escape from jail or prison

Buzzer: Police badge

Chicago overcoat: A coffin

Chicago typewriter or Tommy gun: A Thompson machine gun

Chisel: To swindle, cheat, or work an angle

Cinder dick: Railroad detective

Convincer, gat, heater, or rod: Gun

Copper: Police officer

Dick, gumshoe, or flatfoot: A detective

Drilling, plugging, throwing lead, filling someone with daylight, giving someone lead poisoning: Shooting someone with a gun

G-man: A federal agent (coined by Machine Gun Kelly)

Goons: Enforcers, tough guys, or henchmen

Hotsquat: An electric chair

House dick or house peeper: House detective

Make tracks: To leave abruptly or in a hurry or put distance between yourself and where you were

Micky or Micky Finn: A drink spiked with drugs to knock you out

On sus: Suspected of committing a crime

On the lam: Fleeing from law enforcement

Packing heat or wearing iron: Carrying a gun

Patsy: An innocent man framed for a crime

Sourdough: Counterfeit money

Stool pigeon: An informer or snitch

Take for a ride: To drive someone away to murder them

Taking the rap or taking the fall: Taking responsibility for someone else's crime

Trigger men: Hired gunmen

Insults

- **Abercrombie:** A know-it-all
- **Big it:** A self-centered or conceited person
- **Boob:** A dumb person who makes silly mistakes
- **Can the twit!:** Stop that idle talking^[2]
- **Cement mixer or deadfoot:** Someone who's bad at dancing
- **Crumb:** An unsuccessful or unreliable person, a loser
- **Crust:** To insult
- **Dilly:** Foolish
- **Dingy:** Silly
- **Doggy:** Well dressed, but in a self-conscious way
- **Egg:** A crude person
- **Gold digger:** Someone (typically a woman) who marries for money
- **Greaseball, half portion, wet smack, wet sock, jelly bean:** An unpopular person or loser
- **Nitwittery:** Stupidity
- **Nogoodnik:** A bad or worthless person
- **Off the cob:** Corny
- **Pill:** A disagreeable or bothersome person
- **Screwball:** An odd person (originally from baseball slang)
- **Tightwad:** A cheap or stingy person
- **Tin ear or ickie:** Someone who doesn't like popular music
- **Twit:** A fool or Idiot
- **Wheat:** A person who isn't used to city life
- **Wise guy:** A smart aleck or smart*ss

Dust Bowl and Great Depression

- **Apple Annie:** A woman who sold apples on the street to make ends meet
- **Bank holiday:** A euphemism for closing a bank that was about to fail
- **Black blizzard or black roller:** A dust storm that darkens the sky
- **Blinds:** The platform of a baggage car
- **Bone polisher:** A vicious or dangerous dog
- **California blankets or Hoover blankets:** Newspapers to sleep on or under
- **Chuck a dummy:** To pretend to faint to get money from passersby
- **Duster:** A dust storm
- **Flip a rattler:** To jump into a moving boxcar
- **Gasoline gypsies:** Unemployed people living and traveling in their cars looking for work
- **Gunboat:** An empty can (usually a coffee can) used for cooking
- **Hobo:** A migrant worker, typically without a permanent home
- **Hoover cars or Hoover wagons:** Broken down cars pulled by mules
- **Hoover flags:** Empty pockets turned inside out
- **Hoover hogs:** Wild rabbits that rural people caught for food
- **Hooverville:** A temporary shanty town
- **House dog:** Someone who offers to do chores for money
- **Hungry town:** A town known for being stingy with handouts or aid

- **Jumping the blinds:** Catching a ride on the platform of a baggage car
- **Jungle:** A rural gathering place for hobos
- **K-balling:** Salvaging parts from junked rail cars to build new ones
- **Rent party:** A gathering where guests donate money to help with rent
- **Road sister:** A female hobo
- **Tin can shows:** Movies where viewers bring cans of food for the needy
- **Tin can tourists:** Migrants from the Great Plains who arrived in other states by car
- **Yegg:** A hobo criminal
- **You gave us beer, now give us water:** A Dust Bowl catchphrase and demand to the government by farmers

Food and Drinks

- **Adam and Eve on a raft:** 2 fried or poached eggs on toast
- **All the way:** Chocolate cake or fudge with ice cream
- **Baby:** A glass of milk
- **Barrel of black mud:** A chocolate milkshake
- **Big four:** A duck-egg omelet made with 4 eggs, 4 slices of bacon, and 4 potatoes
- **Black cow:** A root beer float
- **Bossy in a bowl:** Beef stew
- **Break it and shake it:** To put eggs on top of something
- **Cat beer:** milk

- **Chaser of Adam's ale:** A glass of water
- **Chewed fine with a breath:** A hamburger with onion
- **City juice, dog soup, or dog water:** A glass of water (usually referring to city water)
- **Cold spot:** Iced tea
- **Coney Island chicken:** A hot dog
- **Eighty-six:** A restaurant or soda fountain is out of an item (or a customer should be refused service)^[7]
- **Eve with the lid on:** An apple pie
- **Freak:** Orange Coke
- **Hold the hail:** No ice
- **Hounds on an island:** Hot dogs and beans
- **In the air:** In a large glass
- **Mug of murk:** Black coffee
- **Nervous pudding:** Jello
- **Noah's boy with Murphy carrying a wreath:** Ham and potatoes with cabbage
- **On wheels:** To go
- **Punk and gut:** Bread and sausage
- **Scandal soup:** Tea
- **Slugburger:** A hamburger patty made with ground beef stale bread
- **Spla:** Whipped cream
- **Stack of bones:** Boiled spareribs
- **Thirteen:** A boss who is roaming around the workplace
- **Wreck on a raft:** Scrambled eggs on toast

Pop Culture, Jazz, and Radio

- **Canary:** A female singer
- **Cats or alligators:** Fans of swing music
- **Clambake:** A wild swing or a radio program that failed due to on-air mistakes
- **Crawk:** An animal imitator
- **Crooner:** A smooth singer
- **Dillinger:** Very hot swing music
- **Dog house:** A string bass
- **Ether:** Radio waves
- **Gitbox, gitter, or guinea'sharp:** A guitar
- **Gob stick or licorice stick:** A clarinet
- **Gobble-pipe:** Saxophone
- **Grandest Canyon or Hardened Artery:** Broadway in New York;
- **Groanbox:** An accordion
- **Gut-bucket:** Lowdown blues
- **Hep cat:** Someone who loves jazz music and exudes the style
- **Hi-de-ho:** An exclamation of joy or fun used by jazz and dance bands
- **Hop, rag, jolly up, romp, wingding::** A dance or party
- **Hot band:** A band playing improvised jazz
- **Iron horn:** A coronet or trumpet
- **Juke joint:** A cheap, roadside establishment with music, dancing, food, and drinks
- **Kick out:** Improvise
- **Long underwear gang:** A sweet band
- **Madame Cadenza:** A flighty female vocalist
- **Platter:** A record
- **Quit mugging light and mug heavy:** Pick up the beat or speed

- **Ring-a-ding-ding:** A good time at a party
- **Scat singer:** A vocalist who improvises lyrics with nonsense syllables
- **Skin tickler:** A drummer
- **Speako:** Speakeasy
- **Sweet band:** A band playing jazz tunes as written
- **Town crier:** A vocalist who sings too loud
- **Wang it:** Play louder